you compose your photos using an Electronic View Finder (EVF), as you do in a compact camera.

The trick with the new EVIL cams is that they have large sensors. In the case of the Samsung NX10, this sensor is the same size as you'd find in a DSLR, and the others use the Micro Four Thirds format, a sensor which is half the size of a 35mm frame, but a lot bigger than the pinkie-nail-sized sensor in a typical compact. This gives the high image quality and low-light sensitivity of a dSLR. And because they have large sensors, the depth of field is shallower, and you can throw a distracting background out of focus.

Given the tiny pocket-sized lenses for these cameras, you will actually carry them with you. Better still; with an adapter you can use all your current dSLR lenses on the newer, smaller body.

Situated between compact cameras and dSLRs, two main types of MILCs have developed: compact and dSLR-like. Compact-style micros are approximately the size of larger compact cameras and, particularly with pancake lenses, are pocketable to somedegree. dSLR-style MILCs overlap with entry-level dSLRs, providing a contoured body and extensive features, like dSLRs, but in a significantly smaller and lighter body.

The Biggest Party in town

Sensor size varies, but is at the size of entry-level dSLR sensors – the Micro Four Thirds system uses the same size sensor as the Four Thirds System; smallest among dSLRs but over nine times the area of typical compact camera 1/2.5-inch sensors, while the Samsung NX camerasand Sony NEX cameras use a 50 per cent larger APS-C size sensor.

There is some inevitable trade-off between sensor size and compactness of the camera, due to the size of the lens required, so how small a compact-style full-frame MILC may be is unclear, though a full-frame DSLR-style MILC is certainly possible.

Even though the size does make them very desirable, compacts have lost out to dSLRs by being slow. Slow to power up, slow to zoom and slow to actually respond to your trigger finger. EVIL cameras have fixed this, and are as responsive as any entry-level dSLR. Watch out which model you go for, though. The current generation still has some trouble focusing